

Sunday Message

TWENTY-SIXTH SUNDAY IN ORDINARY TIME

THE WORD

Year A • 27 September 2026 • Colour: Green • Psalter Week 2

HUMBLE OF HEART

PHIL 2:1-11



In today's second reading, St Paul offers advice to the church in Philippi on the importance of humility. It would make him completely happy, he tells them, if there were no competition or conceit among them, if they put others' interests before their own. They must be united in love, with a common purpose and a common mind.

To illustrate his point, Paul then includes a poem or hymn about the humility of Jesus: how he emptied himself to become human and humbled himself further still by accepting death on a cross. But God had raised Jesus up and given him a name above all other names.

Jesus is our model of humility. The only ambition the Christian must have is to love and serve others. ■

DO

Holiness is reacting with meekness and humility, Pope Francis said. Do you think people see you as humble?

SAY

"Lord, open my eyes and heart to see and serve you in my sisters and brothers. Amen."

PRAY

This is World Day of Migrants and Refugees. Pray for migrants and refugees, that they will be treated with respect as children of God.

LEARN

The proof of our faith is in our living of it

The Christian is called to a life of love and service

It's never too late to say "yes" to God

REFLECT

The 17-year-old was working with a gang building a road in the Texas hill country in the 1920s. The road was being built by hand, and the tall, gangly teenager was pushing a scoop, a plough-like instrument with a sharpened front edge, that was pulled by four mules. It was back-breaking work, difficult even for older, stronger men. At lunch break each day, as they sat eating, the teenager would talk big to the older men. "He wanted to do something big with his life," one of his workmates recalled. "And he was quite specific about what he wanted to do: 'I'm going to be president of the United States one day,'" he boasted.

They laughed at him, this poor boy from nowhere. It's the sort of idle claim many people make, except this youth was deadly serious. And he began to work towards realising that dream - first as a school teacher, then a congressional aide, then a congressman, then a senator, then U.S. vice-president, and finally, on 22 November 1963, president. Lyndon B. Johnson's lifelong ambition was fulfilled, albeit in the most tragic of circumstances. His life is a study in ambition: how to set a goal, a target, and never let go until it comes true.

Ambition takes many forms. It can be political, like LBJ. Or to be rich or famous, or to succeed in business or sport.

But what does ambition mean for the follower of Jesus? Christian ambition is the opposite of worldly ambition. It turns our usual understanding of ambition on its head. It is about being least, being last, being a servant, being little, being humble.

Jesus was big into humility. He chose the sick over the healthy, the weak over the powerful, the poor over the rich. He didn't select scholars and big shots as his apostles but fishermen and ordinary types. He practised humility. He washed feet, mixed with outcasts and died with criminals. "I have given you an example," he said, "that you also must follow."

What does it mean for us to be humble?

First, to be humble is to be self-aware. It is to know we are not perfect, that we are pilgrims on the journey. No matter how hard we try, we come up short. Despite our best efforts, we sin all the time. It's the one thing we all have in common. Humility is being aware of our unworthiness, our shadow side. It means being without ego or conceit. How can we look down on another when we know we're not perfect ourselves?

We acknowledge our humility before Holy Communion when we say, "Lord, I am not worthy that you should come under my roof..." I don't deserve you.

Second, to be humble is to be selfless. It demands that we set aside our selfish obsessions, ambitions, and desires and give ourselves to the other. Humility washes feet and loves without exception. Think of the last judgment scene in Matthew 25. On what basis will God separate the saved from the lost? I was hungry, and you gave me food; thirsty, and you gave me drink; a stranger, and you made me welcome, naked, and you clothed me; sick or in prison, and you came to see me. Humility is selflessness writ large.

Third, to be humble is to be prayerful. Archbishop Fulton Sheen said that "Only the humble can pray, for prayer presumes we need someone and something." Prayer presumes humility. When we ask God for something, or thank God for something, we are admitting our need for God, that on our own we can do nothing. And so we turn to God in our need, our gratitude, our joy, our heartbreak. We place ourselves before the God who gives us life. That's what we do every time we pray. Humility is at the heart of the Christian life. ■